Why Cities Forget Their Rivers

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Introduction

Nearly all old cities were founded on a river, and most of them spent the twentieth century hiding it. Rivers were straightened, culverted and built over until, in many places, people walking above them no longer knew they were there (Pinder, 2018).

This essay argues that cities forgot their rivers not out of carelessness but because forgetting was useful: a buried river made land valuable, removed a smell and a danger, and suited a way of planning that saw water as a technical problem.

Burying the river

In London, the Fleet was covered in stages between 1730 and 1870 as it became an open sewer (Barton, 2014, pp. 45–52).

Engineers of the period described the work as an improvement to public health, and in a limited sense it was. Yet the same decisions turned rivers into infrastructure that only specialists understood.

Bringing them back

Since the 1990s, cities from Seoul to Sheffield have opened up buried streams again. The best-known case, Cheonggyecheon in Seoul, famously, replaced an elevated motorway with a public stream in 2005 (Kim & Lee, 2019).

Daylighting projects are expensive, but they are rarely justified by flood control alone; they are justified by what people do near water once they can see it (Wild, 2021).

Conclusion

Remembering a river is a political act. It means deciding that the slow, visible city is worth the land and the money that the fast, hidden one saved.

References

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